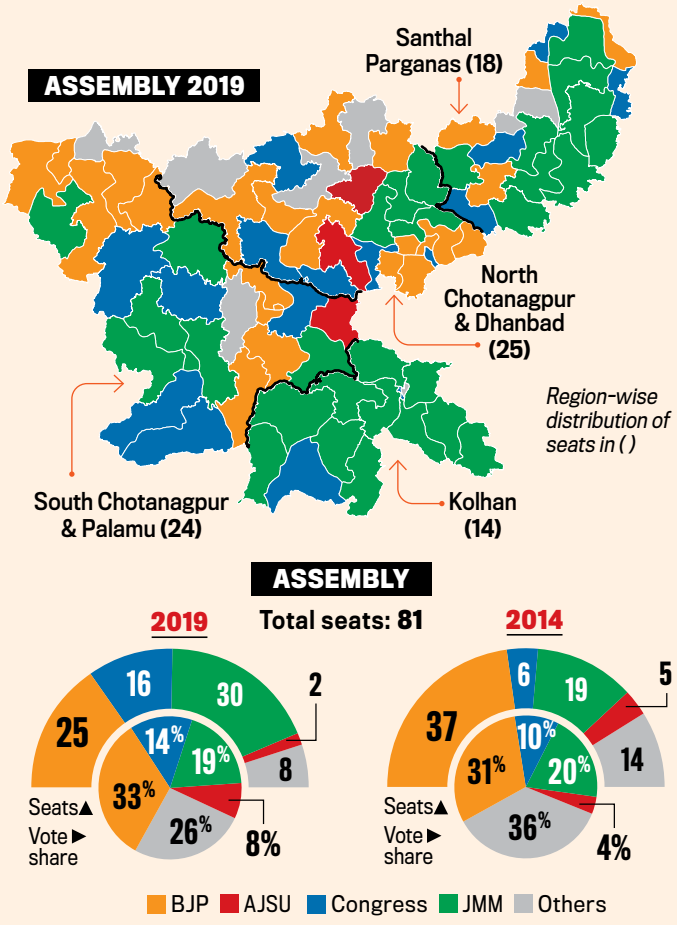
PAST PERFORMANCE



HOW THEY FARE

NDA

STRENGTHS

↘ Quick on the draw in deciding seat-sharing and candidates

WEAKNESS

↘ The tribal vote remains alienated

I.N.D.I.A

STRENGTHS

↘ Solid tribal base, welfare initiatives, Kalpana Soren emerging as a leader in her own right

WEAKNESSES

↘ Growing anti-incumbency, disarray in the alliance

of forged documents for 8.86 acres of land in the Badgai area of Ranchi.

While this may have generated sympathy in Soren's favour, the disarray in the alliance could play spoiler. No one missed the fact that on the day of his media interaction, when seat-sharing details were being discussed, Soren was flanked by Congress leaders, there was no one from the RJD or the Left. What appeared as strategic secrecy was perhaps nothing more than a lack of consensus within the INDIA bloc. Especially as both RJD scion Tejashwi Yadav and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi were in Ranchi on October 19 but there was no picture of them meeting. On the same day, Tejashwi posted on X that the final decision on seat allocation would rest with RJD president Lalu Prasad, taking into account the party's "strong position and social support base". Soren did meet Tejashwi in Ranchi two days later, suggesting that all is well, but the truth is that the RJD won only one of the seven seats it contested in 2019. This perhaps explains the Congress and JMM's reluctance to spare it more seats in the current round of negotiations.

THE MAIN BATTLE APART, THERE'LL BE SEVERAL LEGACY BATTLES AND ONES THAT WILL DECIDE THE FATE OF THE LIKES OF BABULAL MARANDI

Both sides, however, have discovered that they do better when in alliance. So, the JMM and Congress could win only 25 seats between them in 2014, a tally they improved to 47 in 2019 when they fought together. Likewise, the BJP secured only 25 seats in 2019 when it fought without an alliance partner, compared to the 42 it managed when fighting in alliance with AJSU in 2014. The JD(U) and LJP, now part of the NDA in Jharkhand, fared even worse in 2019, forfeiting deposits in the seats they contested and getting just 2 per cent of the vote share. Both alliances must get their acts together if they have to make a go of it at the hustings.

CHALLENGES BEFORE BJP

This time round, the NDA's coordination seems better than that of the INDIA bloc. Jharkhand has also been a BJP stronghold for long, the party having ruled the state for 13 of the 24 years of its existence. The dominance was reaffirmed in the Lok Sabha election earlier this year, when the NDA won nine of the state's 14 parliamentary seats. As former CM Marandi put it, "We maintained leads in 51 assembly segments. Our task now is to secure an even larger majority in the assembly."

The BJP's troubles lie elsewhere—in the 28 constituencies reserved for the Scheduled Tribes (STs), who make up 28 per cent of the electorate. The party has been seeing a steady attrition in its vote in the tribal belt since 2019, when it won just two